Muhammad Usman Naeem

usman.naeem@tufts.edu
usman-naeem.com

Education

Tufts University — Medford, MA, USA
Ph.D., Economics & Public Policy — Expected 2027
Fields: Environmental; Development; Behavioural; Public

Lahore University of Management Sciences — Lahore, Pakistan
M.S., Economics — 2016

National University of Singapore — Singapore
B.A., Economics — 2009

Research Positions

Harvard University, Department of Economics — Cambridge, MA, USA
Visiting Fellow — Jan–Jun 2026

International Growth Centre — Pakistan
Country Economist — 2015–2021

References

Steve Cicala	**Michael Greenstone**	**Gabriel Kreindler**	**Kyle Emerick**
steve.cicala@tufts.edu	mgreenst@uchicago.edu	gkreindler@g.harvard.edu	kyle.emerick@tufts.edu

Job Market Paper

"The Idle Margin: Why Everyday Conservation Goes Undone"

Abstract. Vehicle idling—leaving the engine running while stopped—poses a recurring conservation puzzle: for sufficiently long stops, switching off saves drivers money on fuel while reducing emissions, so private and social incentives point in the same direction. Why, then, do drivers persist in idling? In partnership with a leading telematics firm in Pakistan, I collect 10-second GPS data on ignition status, speed, and location from 6,621 private vehicles. The average vehicle idles for 27 minutes per observed day. At baseline, drivers hold widespread misperceptions about whether warming up an engine extends engine life and how long a stop must last before shutting off saves fuel or reduces environmental harm. I use a randomised additive design varying private information, social information, payments, and an in-car reminder technology. Private information reduces daily idling from stops longer than 30 seconds by 1.8 minutes, or 9% of the control mean, and the effect persists after treatment ends. Estimated benefits are 3.7 times programme costs over the eight-week intervention, with about half accruing directly to drivers through fuel savings. Adding either social information or payments produces no detectable additional reduction. By contrast, activating the reminder device *increases* idling by 1.0 minute, with the increase concentrated in long spells—a pattern consistent with procrastination. The results show that everyday conservation failures can persist even when private and social incentives align—and that interventions meant to correct them can backfire.

Working Papers

"Subsidies and Debt under Nonlinear Electricity Pricing"
with Robin Burgess, Tim Dobermann, Michael Greenstone, and Faraz Hayat

"Preaching Against Power Theft"
with Robin Burgess, Tim Dobermann, Michael Greenstone, and Faraz Hayat

"Hardening the Grid: Technology versus Enforcement"
with Robin Burgess, Tim Dobermann, Michael Greenstone, and Faraz Hayat

Selected Work in Progress

"Technology Subsidies and Crop Residue Burning"
with B. Kelsey Jack, Ben Moscona, and Michael Greenstone

"Small Farms, Coordination, and Air Pollution"
with Steve Cicala and Kyle Emerick

"Industrial Pollution and Emissions Disclosure"
with Michael Greenstone

Research Grants

Total funding as PI/Co-PI: over $1.1 million.

£57,463 (IGC); $13,972 (Weiss)	The Idle Margin: Why Everyday Conservation Goes Undone
£277,762 (IGC)	Subsidies and Debt under Nonlinear Electricity Pricing
$167,904 (Weiss; K-CAI); £64,097 (IGC)	Preaching Against Power Theft
£124,677 (IGC); $24,874 (Weiss)	Hardening the Grid: Technology versus Enforcement
$109,938 (ATAI; DERF); £24,919 (IGC)	Technology Subsidies and Crop Residue Burning
£31,172 (IGC)	Small Farms, Coordination, and Air Pollution
£66,272 (IGC)	Industrial Pollution and Emissions Disclosure

Presentations (* forthcoming)

2027	Econometric Society CSW Asia Meeting*
2026	NEUDC*; SMU–Jinan / WB–GWU Urbanization & Development Conference*; Harvard, Cities & Development Conference*; LUMS*; Tufts, NFEPP Workshop*; Harvard, Development Advising Group
2025	Stanford, Behavioral Public Economics Boot Camp; Tufts, NFEPP Workshop
2024	Berkeley, Environmental & Energy Economics Summer School; Tufts, NFEPP Workshop
2023	MIT, Behavioral Economics; Tufts, NFEPP Workshop

Teaching

Tufts University — Medford, MA, USA

Teaching Assistant, Advanced Empirical Methods for Doctoral Students	2026–2027
Tutor, Intermediate Macroeconomic Theory (undergraduate)	2025–2026
Course Assistant, Behavioral Economics (graduate)	2023–2026